



Understanding the Stages of Dementia

A family overview — what to expect, and what helps most, at each stage.

Dementia doesn't arrive all at once, and it doesn't move at the same speed for everyone. But it does tend to travel through recognizable stages. Knowing roughly where you are takes some of the fear out of the road ahead — and tells you where to put your energy today. Here is the map, in plain language: first the **three broad stages** families use, then the fuller **clinical picture**, side by side.



Where care usually happens →

Usually home

Home, with help

Often a care home

The fuller map

STAGE	WHAT YOU'LL SEE	TYPICAL TIME HERE	ABOUT LIKE A CHILD OF...
Before dementia NORMAL AGING	Everyday forgetfulness — a name, where the keys went. Fully independent; still working, driving, managing life.	Years–decades	—
Early MILD · MCI → MILD	Slips others start to notice — missed appointments, repeating, getting lost somewhere new, trouble with money, planning, or complex tasks. Still living independently, with a little oversight.	~2–7 years	a capable school-age child's independence
Middle MODERATE	Needs help choosing clothes and with everyday tasks; no longer safe on their own for long. Memory of recent events is short.	~1½ years	about 5 years old
Middle MODERATELY SEVERE	Needs help dressing, then bathing, then the toilet; bladder and later bowel accidents begin. This is when behaviours peak — sundowning, wandering, suspicion, repeating.	~1–2+ years (in steps)	about 2–5 years old
Late SEVERE · END-STAGE	Speech narrows to a few words, then none; walking, sitting up, smiling, and holding the head up are gradually lost. Needs total care — and still feels touch, voice, and music.	~1–2+ years	from ~2 years down to a few months

Comfort-focused and hospice care usually enter the conversation in the later part of the middle stage and into the late stage, as a person needs more and more help. It is never "giving up" — it is choosing comfort and dignity as the goal.

Why the child comparison?

Dementia tends to unwind abilities in roughly the **reverse order a child gains them** — the skills learned last are often the first to fade, right down to walking and, at the very end, holding up the head. This is **not** about treating an adult like a child, and it never means less dignity or respect. It's simply a way to understand what's happening — and to bring the right kind of patience. You wouldn't scold a small child for a wet bed or a spilled cup; the same gentleness is exactly what fits here.

Two things that stay true at every stage

Behaviour is communication. When someone is agitated, resistant, or upset, they're almost always telling you about a need they can no longer name — pain, fear, hunger, boredom, a full bladder. Find the need and the behaviour usually settles. It is rarely defiance.

A sudden change is medical until proven otherwise. The disease moves slowly. If confusion, agitation, or sleepiness arrives *fast* — over hours or a day or two — think infection, pain, or a new medication first. That is often **delirium**, it is frequently reversible, and it needs a phone call, not a behaviour strategy.

This map follows **Alzheimer's disease**, the most common dementia. Other kinds — vascular, Lewy body, frontotemporal — don't always move through these steps in the same order or at the same pace. Use it as a compass, not a calendar. Every person is different, and the timeframes above are rough averages, nothing more.

You don't have to figure this out alone

The Dementia House Call sends free, plain-language **letters** for families — the same things a good house call would tell you, for the moments this map only names. Join at **thedementiahousecall.com**, and watch for our stage-by-stage guides.

The Dementia House Call. This overview is general education for families and is not medical advice; it does not create a doctor-patient relationship and does not replace your own physician. Anything that looks like a sudden change, an infection, or an injury needs assessing, not managing — if you're unsure, assume it does and make the call. © 2026 The Dementia House Call.

Built on established clinical frameworks — the Functional Assessment Staging Test (FAST; Reisberg), the retrogenesis model of dementia, and the Palliative Performance Scale — translated into plain language for families.